

Platform Work and Decent Work Deficits in Sub-Saharan Africa: A Literature Review

Uduehi Florence Anuoluwapo
Student, Employment Relations and Human Resource Management
[Olabisi Onabanjo University]

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Abstract

This paper reviews existing literature to examine whether platform work in Sub Saharan Africa aligns with the International Labour Organization's (ILO) Decent Work Agenda. This review draws on three key sources: ILO research report on digital labour platforms, a paper by Graham et al. on digital labour platforms in Sub-Saharan Africa and Southeast Asia, and Ayentimi et al review on the gig economy and sustainable development in Sub Saharan Africa. These sources chosen for this review are to analyze and understand how platform work affects workers' rights, social protection, working conditions, and access to decent work across the region.

The review is centered around five themes: **Employment opportunities, Employment status and labour rights, Social Protection, Algorithm management and worker dignity, and Collective action and Social dialogue**. Although platform work is known for its nature of creating income opportunities especially for young people and women who face barriers to formal employment, still, the evidence consistently shows that these jobs often lack the protections linked to decent work. In the platform work, workers frequently experience insecure income, limited legal protection, inadequate social security, and restricted opportunities for collective representation.

This review also highlights crucial gaps in the existing literature. Most studies focus on only a few countries, leaving much of Sub Saharan Africa under research. Also, there is limited evidence on how gender influences workers' experiences and limited policy frameworks designed for labour markets influenced by widespread informality. This paper concludes by discussing the implications of these findings and offers recommendations for governments, the ILO, platform companies and support the effective implementation of the 2026 ILO convention on Decent Work in the Platform Economy across Sub Saharan Africa.

Keywords: gig economy, platform work, decent work, Sub-Saharan Africa, digital labour, informal economy, International Labour Organization.

1. Introduction

In recent years, digital labour platforms have become an increasingly important part of the global market. By connecting workers with clients through online applications and websites, these platforms have created new ways for people to earn income outside the traditional employment relationships. The International Labour Organization (ILO, 2026a) gave a report that there are about 650 active digital platforms operating worldwide, this shows the rapid growth of the gig economy. This expansion has been driven by wider internet access, increasing smartphone use, and the growing demand for flexible forms of work. As a result, platform work is most times presented as a logical solution to unemployment and limited job opportunities, particularly in developing countries (Ayentimi et al.,2025).

Despite these opportunities in platform work, there is growing concern about the quality of work provided through digital platforms. While the gig economy gives flexibility and income generating opportunities, many studies point to these exact persistent problems such as insecure earnings, limited legal protection, and inadequate access to social security. These concerns have brought platform work into discussions about the ILO's Decent Work Agenda, which lay emphasis on productive employment, rights at work, social protection, and social dialogue as the very foundation of decent work.

Sub Saharan Africa is an important context for examining these issues. As the region continues to face high levels of unemployment, underemployment, especially among its young people, while informal employment remains the dominant source of work. At the same time, the gradual improvement in mobile technology and internet connectivity have encouraged the rapid expansion of platform-based work across many African countries (Ayentimi et al.,2025). For many workers, gig work is seen as an accessible source of income when formal employment is unavailable. However, whether these opportunities translate into decent and sustainable work remains an open question.

The need to answer this question is made even more important due to the limited evidence available on platform work in Sub Saharan Africa. According to ILO (2026a), Africa has the least comprehensive data on platform workers of any region. Existing studies also concentrate mainly on countries such as South Africa, Kenya, and Nigeria, leaving many other countries largely unstudied (Graham et al.,2017; Ayentimi et al.,2025). This makes it difficult to understand the full extent of decent work deficits across the region to design policies that respond to local realities.

Against this background, this paper asks the following research question: **To what extent does platform work in Sub Saharan Africa meet or undermine the ILO's Decent Work Agenda?** To answer this question, the paper critically reviews existing literature using the four pillars of the Decent Work Agenda: **employment opportunities, rights at work, social protection, and social dialogue** as its analytical framework. Rather than simply summarizing previous studies, this review compares their findings, highlights areas where there is an agreement and disagreement, and identifies important gaps that require further research.

The remainder of this paper is organized into five sections. Section Two introduces the conceptual framework and discusses the gig economy, the ILO's Decent Work Agenda, and the labour market in Sub Saharan Africa context. Section Three presents the thematic literature review. Section Four synthesises the findings and discusses the major research gaps. Finally, Section Five concludes the paper by outlining the main policy implications and suggesting directions for future research.

2. Conceptual Framework

2.1 The Gig Economy

The gig economy refers to a form of work in which individuals earn income by completing short-term or task based jobs, usually through digital platforms. Unlike traditional employment, the gig work arrangements are often temporary and do not provide workers with regular salaries or any standard employment benefits. Instead, workers are commonly engaged as independent contractors and are paid for individual tasks or projects rather than holding permanent positions (Ayentimi et al., 2025).

Platform work generally falls into two broad categories. The first is **location based work**, this is where services are delivered in person through digital applications. An example of this include ride hailing platforms such as Uber, Bolt, InDrive, and food delivery services such as Glovo and Jumia Food. While the second category is **online or web-based work**, here, tasks are completed remotely through platforms such as Upwork and Fiverr. These tasks range from data entry and transcription to specialized services like graphic design, software development, and content writing (ILO, 2026a).

The two categories of platform work are becoming more common across Sub Saharan Africa, although their growth differs across countries depending on factors such as Internet access, digital skills, and labour market conditions. While these platforms have expanded opportunities for income generation, they have also changed the nature of employment relationships. Graham et al. (2017) argue that many platforms classify workers as **independent contractors** regardless of the amount of control they exercise over the work. This obvious classification enables platforms to avoid many of the legal responsibilities normally associated with employers, leaving workers with fewer protections under national labour laws.

Understanding these qualities of the gig economy is important because they shape many of the decent work challenges discussed throughout this review. Although digital platforms create new opportunities for employment which is undisputable, they also raise important questions about workers' rights, job security, and access to social protection.

2.2 The ILO's Decent Work Agenda

This review adopts the International Labour Organization's Decent Work Agenda as its main analytical framework because it provides a widely accepted standard for assessing the quality of employment. The Decent Work Agenda was introduced by the ILO in 1999, the framework goes beyond job creation by considering whether work is productive, fairly rewarded, secure, and respectful of workers' rights.

The Agenda is built around four interconnected pillars. The first is **employment opportunities**, which focuses on access to productive and freely chosen work. The second is **rights at work**, covering fundamental labour rights such as freedom from forced labour, child labour, discrimination, and unsafe working conditions. The third pillar, **social protection**, focuses on workers' access to benefits including healthcare, paid leave, sick pay, and pensions. The final pillar, **social dialogue**, lays emphasis on workers'

right to organize, join representative organizations, and participate in collective bargaining (Ayentimi et al , 2025).

These four pillars provide a useful framework for evaluating platform work because they address issues that frequently appear in discussions of the gig economy, including job insecurity, limited legal protection, and restricted access to social benefits. However, applying the framework to Sub Saharan Africa also presents challenges. Much of the region's workforce operates within the informal economy, where many workers lack these protections regardless of whether they participate in platform work.

Even with these limitations, the Decent Work Agenda remains one of the most comprehensive frameworks available for assessing employment quality. It therefore provides a suitable lens for examining whether the rapid growth of platform work in Sub Saharan Africa represents genuine progress towards decent work or simply extends existing forms of labour market insecurity into the digital economy.

3. Literature Review

3.1 Gig Work as an Opportunity in Sub-Saharan Africa

One of the main arguments in the literature is that platform work has created new income opportunities for many people who struggle to access formal employment. This is particularly relevant in Sub Saharan Africa, where high unemployment and underemployment continue to limit opportunities for young people and women. Ayentimi et al. (2025) argue that the gig economy has widened access to work by providing flexible earning opportunities that fit around workers' personal circumstances. For many people, platform work offers a sure way to generate income when few alternatives are available.

Graham et al. (2017) also acknowledge this opportunity, but they present a more cautious assessment. Their study shows that while digital platforms connect workers to clients across national borders, they also expose workers to intense global competition. Instead of creating stable employment, these platforms often encourage workers to compete by accepting lower pay in order to secure jobs. As more workers enter the market, it becomes more difficult to avoid the increasing downward pressure on earnings.

These contrasting perspectives highlight important differences. **Creating work is not the same as creating decent work.** Although platform work may increase employment opportunities, the evidence suggests that these opportunities in reality are often irregular income, limited job security, and few employment protections. In other words, access to work is not enough to satisfy the employment opportunities pillar of the ILO's Decent Work Agenda.

This tension is particularly important in Sub-Saharan Africa. Given the limited availability of formal jobs, many workers may willingly accept precarious platform work because it provides some income rather than none. However, this should not be seen as evidence that the quality of work is adequate. Instead, it reflects the difficult labour market conditions that shake workers' choices. The literature therefore

suggests that while platform work contributes to employment generation, its ability to deliver genuine decent work is limited.

3.2 Employment Status and Labour Rights

The second pillar of the ILO's Decent Work Agenda focuses on **rights at work**, including protection from exploitation, fair working conditions, and access to fundamental labour rights. For platform workers in Sub Saharan Africa, one the most known challenges within this area is the question of **employment status**. Unlike traditional employees, many gig workers are classified by platforms as **independent contractors** rather than employees. This classification has major implications because it determines whether workers can access legal protection normally associated with employment.

Graham et al. (2017) highlights that digital labour platforms often maintain that workers are independent service providers, even where platforms exercise significant control over how work is performed. This creates a tension between the formal classification of workers and the reality of their working relationship. In most cases, platforms determine access to tasks, monitor performance through ratings, and establish the conditions under which services are delivered. Despite this level of control, workers may still be excluded from employee protections.

The consequences of this classification are particularly serious in Sub Saharan Africa, where labour regulation and enforcement mechanisms are already limited. Workers without employee status may lack access to minimum wage protections, paid leave, social security contribution, and collective bargaining rights. These exclusions directly conflict with the rights at work pillar of the Decent Work Agenda, which emphasises that all workers should have access to basic labour protection regardless of the form their work takes.

Ayentimi et al. (2025) further demonstrate that gig workers in the region often operate outside established systems of worker representation. Unlike employees in formal workplaces who may rely on trade unions or collective bargaining processes, platform workers frequently negotiate their working conditions individually. This creates a significant power imbalance between workers and digital platforms, particularly where workers depend on platforms for income but have limited influence over platform decisions.

However, **the problem is not only the absence of regulation but also the difficulty of applying traditional labour laws to a changing employment model**. Digital platforms often operate across national borders, while many regulatory systems remain designed around conventional employer-employee relationships. This creates uncertainty about who should be responsible for protecting workers' rights. The adoption of international discussions of decent work standards for platform workers represents an important step towards addressing this regulatory gap.

These challenges persist because platform work has developed faster than labour regulation. Digital platforms now operate across national borders, making national labour laws difficult to apply, while many governments in Sub Saharan Africa have limited capacity to regulate platform based work effectively.

The adoption of the ILO Convention on Decent Work in the Platform Economy at the 114th International Labour Conference in 2026 marks an important step towards addressing these challenges by establishing an international standard for platform workers. However, the Convention does not automatically change national labour laws. **Its impact will solely depend on whether member States ratify it, incorporate its provisions into respective domestic legislations, and enforce them effectively.** For many countries in Sub Saharan Africa, this implementation process itself is likely to be as important as the Convention itself.

3.3 Social Protection Deficit

The third pillar of the ILO's Decent Work Agenda, social protection, focuses on ensuring that workers have access to support systems that protect them against income insecurity, illness, and other risks associated with work and life. Among platform workers in Sub-Saharan Africa, this remains one the most significant areas of concern. Although gig work creates opportunities for earning income, many workers operate without the social protections that traditionally come with employment.

Ayentimi et al. (2025) highlights that income from platform work is often unpredictable, with many workers depending on multiple platforms or combining gig work with other informal activities to maintain a stable livelihood. This suggests that for many workers, platform work functions less as a secure employment pathway and more as a survival strategy within already uncertain labour markets.

The absence of employer-provided benefits further increases workers' vulnerability. Unlike employees in formal employment relationships, gig workers generally do not receive employer contributions towards health insurance, pensions, paid leave, or income support during periods when they are unable to work. These gaps directly go against the social protection pillar of the Decent Work Agenda, which recognizes that workers should have access to mechanisms that provide security beyond immediate earnings.

However, the social protection challenges facing platform workers cannot be viewed only as a demerit of platform work itself. **They are also connected to broader structural weaknesses within Sub Saharan African labour markets.** A large proportion of workers in the region were already excluded from formal social protection systems before the expansion of digital platforms. In this sense, platform work does not create the problem entirely; **rather it extends existing patterns of insecurity into a new form of employment.**

The classification of gig workers as independent contractors further complicates efforts to address this problem. Because platforms generally do not recognize themselves as employers, they have limited obligations to provide employment-related benefits. At the same time, many governments in the region lack portable social protection systems that allow workers to maintain access to benefits regardless of their employment status.

The ILO (2026a) also highlights the limited availability of reliable data on platform workers in Africa. This creates an additional policy challenge because governments cannot effectively design protection mechanisms without understanding the size, characteristics, and needs of the workforce involved.

Expanding social protection to workers therefore requires not only new policy approaches but also improved data collection and stronger institutional capacity.

Overall, the literature indicates that platform work in Sub-Saharan Africa operates within a major social protection gap. While digital platforms may expand access to income opportunities, they have not been backed up by equivalent systems of security and worker protection. Without innovative approaches such as portable benefits or inclusive social insurance schemes, **the growth of platform work risks reproducing the same vulnerabilities found in the region's informal economy.**

3.4 Algorithmic Management and Worker Dignity

Beyond the issues of employment status and social protection, platform work also raises important questions about worker autonomy and dignity. The ILO's Decent Work Agenda advocates that workers should be protected from unfair treatment and should have the ability to participate in decisions that affect their working lives. However, digital platforms increasingly rely on algorithmic management systems that influence how tasks are allocated, how performance is evaluated, and how workers maintain access to employment opportunities.

Graham et al. (2017) demonstrate that workers' access to assignments on digital platforms is often influenced by reputation systems, customer ratings, and platform performance metrics. While these systems are designed to improve efficiency and match clients with workers, they can also create unequal power relationships. Workers may be unable to challenge decisions made through these systems, particularly when low ratings or poor performance scores affect their visibility or ability to receive future assignments.

This creates a form of managerial control that differs from traditional workplaces. Instead of direct supervision by a human manager, control is exercised through digital systems, data collection, and automated decision-making processes. The result is that workers may experience significant pressure to maintain high ratings and remain constantly available, while having limited knowledge of how platform decisions are made.

The implications of algorithmic management are particularly significant in Sub Saharan Africa because many platform workers are already operating within insecure labour markets. Where workers lack stable income, employment benefits, or alternative opportunities, dependence on platform systems can increase their vulnerability. The inability to negotiate platform rules or challenge automated decisions further weakens workers' bargaining power.

However, algorithmic management should not be viewed only as a technological problem. The deeper issue is **the relationship between technological control and labour rights**. Digital systems that are inherently harmful; **they can improve coordination and create new opportunities. The concern arises when platforms use these systems without adequate transparency, accountability, or mechanisms through which workers can express their concerns.**

The literature therefore suggests that algorithmic management represents a new dimension of workplace power. While traditional employment relationships involved visible forms of managerial authority, **platform work often shifts control into less visible digital systems.** Ensuring decent work in the platform economy will require not only access to employment but also a greater transparency, fairness, and worker participation in the systems that govern their work.

3.5 Collective Action and Social Dialogue

The fourth pillar of the ILO's Decent Work Agenda emphasises social dialogue, that includes workers' right to organize, engage in collective bargaining, and participate in decisions that affect their working conditions. These rights have traditionally been protected through trade unions and other forms of worker representation. However, the nature of platform work presents significant challenges to these conventional approaches.

Graham et al. (2017) argue that the structure of digital labour platforms makes collective organization very difficult. Platform workers are geographically dispersed, they often work independently, and compete with large numbers of workers across national borders. In such an environment, traditional forms of industrial action, such as strikes or collective bargaining, become more difficult to organize and sustain. Workers who stop accepting jobs may also be replaced quickly by others who are willing to continue working, reducing the effectiveness of collective action.

As a result, many platform workers in Sub Saharan Africa have limited opportunities to negotiate wages, challenge unfair platform decisions, or influence the conditions under which they work. This weakens one of the central pillars of the Decent Work Agenda, as workers have little collective power to balance the influence of digital platforms.

Despite these challenges, the literature suggests that new forms of workers organization are beginning to emerge. Ayentimi et al. (2025) identify cases of strikes and coordinated protests among platform workers in countries such as South Africa, Kenya, and Nigeria. Although these actions remain relatively limited, it means platform workers are increasingly seeking ways to defend their interests despite the fragmented nature of gig work.

Similarly, Graham et al. (2017) observe that workers increasingly rely on digital communication tools, including social media platforms and messaging applications to exchange information, discuss working conditions, and coordinate collective responses to platform policies. While these networks do not always function like traditional trade unions, they seem to represent new forms of worker solidarity that reflect the realities of platform-based employment.

Nevertheless, important gaps still remain in the existing literature. Much of the available evidence comes from only a small number of countries, making it difficult to fully determine whether similar forms of collective organization are also emerging across the wider Sub Saharan African region. There is also limited research on the long-term effectiveness of these new forms of worker representation and the conditions under which they can influence platform governance.

Overall, the literature indicates that although social dialogue remains one of the weakest dimensions of decent work in the platform economy, yet, workers are not entirely passive. Instead, **they are beginning to experiment with new forms of collective organization that may reshape labour representation in the digital economy.** Whether these emerging initiatives can develop into similar effective systems of worker voice remains an important question for future research.

4. Synthesis and Critical Analysis

The literature reviewed in this paper presents a consistent picture of platform work in Sub Saharan Africa. Although digital labour platforms have expanded access to employment and income generating opportunities, particularly for young people and women, these opportunities rarely meet the standard set out in the ILO's Decent Work Agenda. Across the four pillars of decent work, the evidence points to recurring challenges which includes insecure employment, weak labour protections, inadequate social protection, limited worker representation, and increasing managerial control through digital technologies.

A key insight that emerges from the literature is that the debate should not be framed as whether **platform work is beneficial or harmful. Rather, the evidence suggests that platform work produces both opportunities and vulnerabilities at the same time.** For many workers, it provides access to income that might otherwise be unavailable. However, these opportunities are often accompanied by irregular earnings, legal uncertainty, and limited employment rights. **This suggests that expanding access to work should not automatically be seen as progress towards decent work.**

The review also shows that many of the challenges experienced by platform workers are not entirely new. Instead, digital platforms often reproduce existing labour market inequalities in a different form. Sub Saharan Africa already has record of high level of informal employment, limited social protection coverage, and weak enforcement of labour legislation. Platform work frequently builds on these existing conditions rather than creating them. As a result, workers who were already vulnerable within the informal economy often remain vulnerable when they enter the platform economy.

Another important finding is that the current labour regulations have struggled to keep pace with technological change. Most labour laws were developed around traditional employer-employee relationships, whereas platform work introduces more complex arrangements that involve digital platforms, clients, and workers operating across different legal jurisdictions. This regulatory gap contributes to uncertainty over employment status and limits the effectiveness of existing labour protection mechanisms.

The literature also reveals important gaps that should be addressed by future research. Most empirical studies focus on only a few countries, particularly South Africa, Kenya and Nigeria, making it difficult to draw conclusions about the wider Sub Saharan African region. In addition, a little attention has been paid to **how gender, disability, educational background, or rural urban differences shape workers' experiences within the platform economy.** Further research that goes beyond these geographical and demographics would provide a more complete understanding of decent work deficits across the region.

Finally, many policy recommendations presented in the literature assume levels of institutional capacity that are not always in Sub Saharan African countries. While stronger regulation and expanded worker protections are important objectives, likewise effective reforms must also reflect the realities of labour markets characterized by widespread informality and limited administrative capacity. Future policy frameworks should therefore balance international labour standards with practical approaches that can be implemented within local institutional contexts.

In sum, the literature demonstrates that the **central challenge is not the existence of platform work itself, but the absence of labour institutions capable of ensuring that technological innovation is matched by adequate worker protection.** The long term success of the platform economy in Sub Saharan Africa will therefore depend not only on creating job opportunities, but also on ensuring that those opportunities meet the standard of fairness, security, and dignity associated with decent work.

The findings of this review should also be considered alongside a major recent development worth mentioning in international labour policy. In 2026, the ILO adopted the Convention on Decent Work in the Platform Economy at its 114th International Labour Conference. The Convention establishes international standards for platform work and responds to many of the labour challenges discussed in this review. However, adopting an international convention is only the first step. The real improvement will depend on how the government translates these standards into respective national labour laws and whether they have the capacity to enforce them. In Sub Saharan Africa, where labour markets are largely informal and regulatory systems are often under-resourced, implementation is most likely to remain a major challenge. Future studies should therefore examine not only the Convention itself but also how it is applied in practice and whether it leads to better outcomes for platform workers.

5. Conclusion and Policy Recommendations

This review examined whether platform work in Sub Saharan Africa aligns with the International Labour Organization's (ILO) Decent Work Agenda. The evidence shows that while digital labour platforms have expanded access to employment and income generating opportunities, particularly for young people and women, still, they have not consistently delivered the conditions associated with decent work. Across the literature, common challenges include job insecurity, limited labour rights, inadequate social protection, algorithmic control, and weak opportunities for collective representation. These findings suggest that **platform work has created new forms of employment without providing equivalent protections for workers.**

At the same time, the review also shows that many of these challenges are rooted in broader market conditions rather than platform work alone. High levels of informal employment, weak labour market institutions, and limited social protection systems have shaped workers' experiences long before the growth of digital platforms. Platform work has therefore exposed and in many cases, increased existing decent work deficits instead of creating entirely new ones.

The adoption of the ILO Convention on Decent Work in the Platform Economy at the 114th International Labour Conference in 2026 represents an important step towards strengthening international labour standards for platform workers. **However, it is important to note that the Convention alone will not enforce working conditions. Its success will depend on whether member States ratify it, align their national labour laws with its provisions, and develop the institutional capacity needed to enforce those standards effectively.**

To address the challenges identified in this review, governments across Sub Saharan Africa should **strengthen legal protections for platform workers by reviewing existing labour laws in light of the new ILO Convention and ensuring that workers have access to basic labour rights regardless of their employment classification.** Efforts should also be made to **expand social protection systems so that platform workers can access benefits such as health insurance, pensions, and income protection.** In addition, governments should **encourage meaningful social dialogue by supporting workers' freedom of association and recognizing emerging forms of worker representation within the platform economy.**

Finally, future research should move beyond identifying decent work deficits and start examining how the 2026 ILO Convention is being implemented across Sub Saharan African countries. Comparative studies on ratification, legislative reforms, enforcement, and their impact on platform workers' lived experiences will provide valuable evidence for both policymakers and labour scholars. The future of platform work in the region will depend not only on technological innovation but also on the willingness of governments, platform companies, and workers to build a labour market that combines flexibility with fairness, protection, and dignity. Now is the future.

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